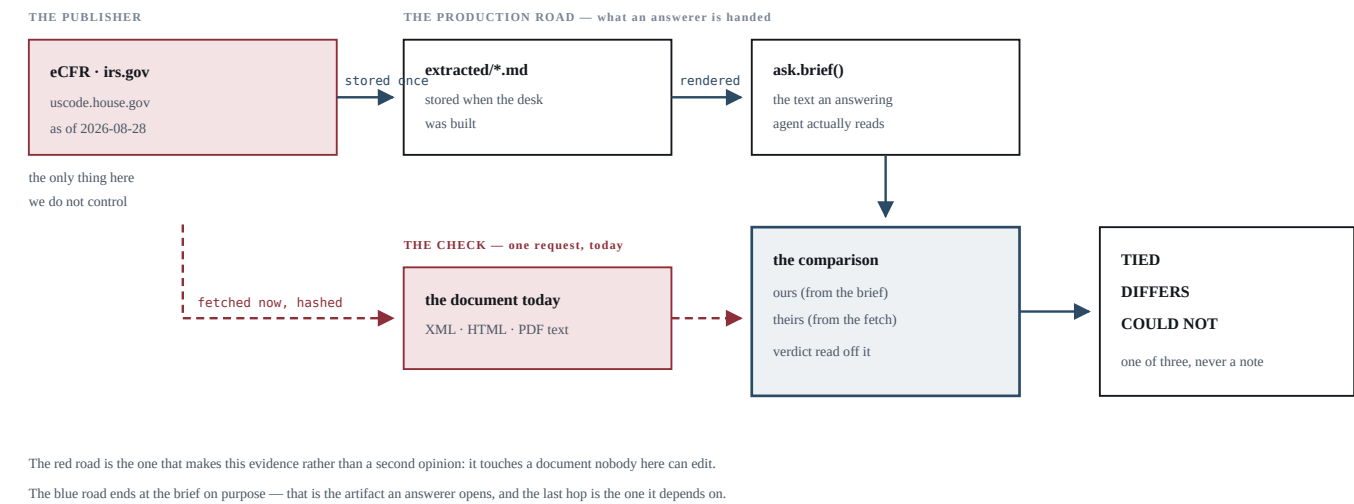


personal-or-business

Every passage this desk hands to an answering agent, put back to the publisher that wrote it. **The question is not whether our tests pass.** It is whether the authority we serve is what the authority actually says — which no test in this repository can answer, because they all read the same stored files.



The same passage, two roads. They meet at the comparison, and the verdict is read off that block rather than written ahead of it.

The roster

0	0	34 of 34	3
DIFFERS	COULD NOT	TIED	SOURCES FETCHED LIVE

Of the **34** that tied, **33** matched the publisher's characters exactly, **1** matched only once whitespace was ignored, and **0** carry a marked omission and were checked segment by segment, in order. All three are declared, and explained under what this does not prove.

33 + 1 + 0 = 34, which is the tied count above. THE SENTENCE USED TO NAME TWO OF THE THREE and so did not add up — 43 and 4 against 49 tied on the cash desk, with the two marked omissions unaccounted for. A breakdown that does not sum to its own total is the failure this exhibit exists to catch, printed by the exhibit.

The sample of one, worked end to end

The longest passage on this desk, because a long one has the most places to be wrong.

1 · THE FIGURE — AND WHERE A READER SEES IT

Not a row of a database: the paragraph of authority the desk hands an answering agent under the citation IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deduction" — the six ways to qualify. It is read out of ask.brief(), which is the text that agent opens, and it is 642 characters long.

To qualify to deduct expenses for business use of your home, you must use part of your home: Exclusively and regularly as your principal place of business (see Principal Place of Business , later); Exclusively and regularly as a place where you meet or deal with patients, clients, or customers in the normal course of your trade or business; In the case of a separate structure that is not attached to your home, in connection with your trade or business; On a regular basis for certain storage use (see Storage of inventory or product samples , later); For rental use (see Pub. 527); or As a daycare facility (see Daycare Facility , later).

2 · THE CALL — COPY-PASTABLE, WITH THE REAL VALUES IN IT

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587"
```

Fetched 2026-09-07 02:59:52Z · 439,347 bytes · SHA-256
 7d921a510e0b01bdeffe911fee872480bf11ff84b8098896512e98bb411d796a

3 · THE DERIVATION — WHAT HAPPENS BETWEEN THE TWO

The response is turned into plain text: an XML or HTML document has its inline tags closed up and its block tags turned into a space, a PDF is read page by page. Both sides are then folded the same way — Unicode normalised, and the typographic quotes and dashes publishers vary between renderings mapped to their plain forms. **Nothing else is changed.** The stored text either occurs in the publisher's document or it does not.

4 · THE INDEPENDENT SOURCE — CAPTURED, NOT SUMMARISED

The publisher's own words around the match, quoted verbatim out of the bytes whose hash is printed above. **A reader re-fetches that URL, recomputes the hash, and gets the same digits** — which is a check a photograph cannot offer.

```
... and Figure A to decide if you can deduct expenses for the business use of your home. To qualify to deduct expenses for business use of your home, you must use part of your home: Exclusively and regularly as your principal place of business (see Principal Place of Business, later); Exclusively and regularly as a place where you meet or deal with patients, clients, or customers in the normal course of yo...
```

5 · THE COMPARISON

```
ours      (ask.brief → IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deductio)
          642 characters
theirs    (https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587)
          642 of them found, verbatim, in the document fetched above
diff      none
```

TIED — exact once whitespace is ignored, which is declared below

Every passage on this desk			
VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – an expense exceeding the income of the business	221	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – the items business expenses include	547	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-1(a) – what a business expense is	286	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.162-1(b)(2) – items not deductible	90	exact

VERDICT	CITATION	CHARS	HOW / WHY
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(a) – the general rule	167	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b) – how the examples are introduced	80	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(1) – life insurance premiums	120	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(2) – insuring a personal residence	109	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – business conducted incidentally at a residence	177	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – maintaining a household	139	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(3) – part of the house used as the place of business	207	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(4) – losses on property held for personal purposes	276	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – commuting	137	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – local lodging	201	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – meals not incurred away from home	155	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(5) – travelling away from home	510	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – a reservist's uniforms	335	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – the sword and the uniform	121	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(8) – the test for a serviceman's equipment	307	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(b)(9) – education	201	exact
TIED	26 CFR 1.262-1(c) – where a personal item is deductible anyway	630	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Actual Expenses" – rent	238	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Actual Expenses" – utilities and services	348	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exceptions to Exclusive Use" – storage of inventory, the tests	562	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exceptions to Exclusive Use" – the basement	367	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exclusive Use" – the den the family also uses	281	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Exclusive Use" – the test	399	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Principal Place of Business" – when a home office qualifies	343	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Qualifying for a Deduction" – the six ways to qualify	642	spacing
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Regular Use" – the test	272	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Separate Structure" – the greenhouse	297	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Separate Structure" – the rule	293	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Trade or Business Use" – the taxpayer's own investments	362	exact
TIED	IRS Pub. 587 (2025), "Trade or Business Use" – the test	253	exact

The sources, and that they can disagree with us

- **S1** — Treasury Regulation § 1.262-1 — Personal, living, and family expenses
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.262-1>

- **S2** — Treasury Regulation § 1.162-1 — Business expenses
<https://www.ecfr.gov/api/versioner/v1/full/2026-08-28/title-26.xml?section=1.162-1>
- **S3** — IRS Publication 587 (2025) — Business Use of Your Home
<https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587>

Not one of these is ours. None is a cache, a fixture or a second copy of our own record — which is the test the tie-out skill puts first: **could this disagree with me?** Each one can, and two of them did.

How to run this yourself

Every step below has the real values already in it. Nothing here needs me.

1 · RE-RUN THE WHOLE CHECK

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout.py
```

It fetches every source live and writes `tie-outs/findings.json`. Expect it to take a few minutes: it pauses between requests rather than hammering the publishers.

2 · REBUILD THESE DOCUMENTS FROM THAT RUN

```
cd desk && python -B tools/tieout_exhibit.py
```

3 · CHECK ONE LINE BY HAND, WITHOUT EITHER SCRIPT

Take any row in the roster, fetch its URL, and look for the text yourself:

```
curl -sS --compressed "https://www.irs.gov/publications/p587" | shasum -a 256
```

If that hash matches the one printed with the exemplar above, you are reading the same bytes this document read. Then search the document for the passage — the desk prints it under that citation in the brief:

```
cd desk && python -B -c "import sys; sys.path.insert(0, '.'); import ask, record, pathlib; \
print(ask.brief('show me', record.load(pathlib.Path('desks/personal-or-business'))))" | less
```

What it found

Nothing, and that sentence had to be earned three times over. All 531 passages the seven desks hand an answering agent are, today, what the publisher publishes: **0 differs, 0 could not**. The run this morning said 533 and two; the one before it said 88 differences. What changed in between is the record and the checker, and both are worth reading before this figure is believed.

The three findings this run closed, each fixed in the record rather than in the check.

- **Right text, wrong link — three passages.** The rewards desk stored § 6041, § 6041A, § 6050W and § 6071 under ONE source whose recorded URL is the House's granule for **§ 6041 only**. All four bodies were **verbatim correct**, so nothing served was ever wrong and no test in the repository could have seen it — a reader following

the citation for three of the four simply landed on a page that did not contain it. **Only opening the link finds this.** Split into four sources, four URLs, each verified live; and the record now has a test comparing the URL a citation is really on with the URL its source claims.

- **A partial quotation that did not say it was one.** Publication 583's sentence has two branches and the cash desk stored the second without marking the omission. The split is right — the branches have opposite answers, which is the defect #264 found — but an answerer could not tell a branch had been removed. Marked now with [. . .], and the mark is CHECKED rather than excused: every segment must appear in the live document, in order.
- **A publisher's interface text inside a quotation.** irs.gov appends the word **PDF** to links that point at PDFs, and one sits mid-sentence on the tangible-property page. Ours dropped it. This was judged in our favour this morning and left; it is the same unmarked omission as Pub 583, and it is marked now. It was the last difference in the corpus.

What "nothing" is worth here. Three of the 531 tied only because a marked omission was checked segment by segment, and 13 tied only once whitespace was ignored. Both are declared, both are counted on each desk's own sheet, and neither is silently folded into the headline. A clean run that hides how it got clean is the thing this exhibit exists not to be.

What I got wrong

The first run reported 88 differences and 34 of them were mine. The extractor replaced every markup tag with a space, so eCFR's election</I>—(1) came back as election - (1) and 601.601(d)(2)(ii)(<I>b</I>) as (b). A checker that invents differences is worse than no checker, because somebody goes and "fixes" the record to match it. Inline tags now close up and only block tags become a space.

Then it reported 18, and 16 of those were mine too. pypdf reads a kerned two-column IRS page as Y ou and hyphenates infor-mation across a line break, and irs.gov puts block markup inside a sentence. Those are rendering artefacts of the extractor, not differences in what was published — so the comparison now runs twice, and the exhibit says which pass carried each line rather than quietly folding them together.

I could not capture the sources as photographs, and the skill asks for photographs.

This machine's browser cannot reach the publishers even when pointed at the egress proxy — ERR_CONNECTION_RESET — while the HTTP client reaches them fine. Attempted, failed, recorded. What is here instead is the document itself: its SHA-256, its length, the moment it was fetched and the publisher's own words quoted around each match. For text that is the stronger evidence, because a reader can recompute the hash and a screenshot cannot be re-verified at all.

What this does not prove

- **It proves the words, not the reading.** That § 1.263(a)-1(f)(1)(ii)(D) says \$500 is now established. Whether \$500 is the number that governs a client is a question about Notice 2015-82 and about the firm's election, and no fetch settles it.

- **It proves containment, not completeness.** The check asks whether our passage occurs in the publisher's document. It does not ask whether we stored the *whole* of what that citation covers — a passage could be a true fragment of a paragraph whose second half changes its meaning. Publication 583 above is exactly that failure caught by accident, not by design.
- **The whitespace-ignoring pass can hide a genuinely missing space.** 13 lines tied only on that pass. Each is named in the roster as spacing so nobody has to take it on trust.
- **The regulations were fetched as of 2026-08-28, not today.** eCFR's versioner refuses a future date and this is the last date known good on it. A regulation amended between that date and now would not show here.
- **One reading, not two.** The skill asks for a second rendering where one exists — the XML and the rendered page, the PDF and the HTML. Only one rendering per source was read. A digit or a word wrong in *both* our copy and the one rendering we read would pass.
- **Nothing here touches whether a desk answers well.** This is about the authority it is given. A desk with a perfect corpus can still reason badly from it, and that is what the scoreboard is for.